

Ats Optimization

Litmus V2 career/resume RAG knowledge-base document.

ATS meaning

ATS stands for Applicant Tracking System. Employers use ATS software to collect, parse, manage, scan, and rank resumes before human review.

Tables and graphics

Complex tables, columns, text boxes, and embedded graphics can cause ATS parsers to drop, scramble, or misread content. Simple, linear formatting is safer.

Job-description terminology

When a job description repeatedly uses a phrase such as “cross-functional collaboration,” candidates should incorporate that exact phrase naturally where it truthfully applies. ATS keyword matching often favors exact or near-exact terminology.

File formats

A .docx or text-based, non-scanned PDF is generally safest for online applications. Scanned image PDFs and unusual formats can fail to parse.

Section headings

Use conventional headings such as Work Experience, Experience, Education, and Skills. Creative headings such as “My Journey” may be ignored or parsed incorrectly.

Keyword stuffing

Legitimate ATS optimization naturally integrates relevant, truthful keywords into real experience and skills. Keyword stuffing unnaturally repeats or hides keywords, including in white or tiny text, to game a score. Newer systems may detect unnatural repetition and recruiters may notice the lack of genuine context.

ATS filtering

Some ATS platforms automatically score and rank resumes and may filter out resumes below a configured relevance or keyword-match threshold before a recruiter sees them.